

NM Prince Constantine Brancoveanu & sons, Steven, Radu & Matthew
& advisor Ianache Vacarescu

(Martyred on Dormition +1714, and commemorated, on the day after, Aug 16.)

A letter from Priest Seraphim. 11th Sunday after Pentecost, and Dormition.

Aug 15/28, 2022

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Today is the commemoration of some great Romanian saints. Adriana (Fabi) is a great venerator of these saints and introduced me to them. We have heard their story in our homeschool co-op, and will doubtless hear it again because it is important to repeat edifying stories. At the end of this letter is something I wrote about the saints, more in the style of the lives of the saints. It is useful to know the story, and it is even more useful to glean bits of wisdom from their story and to change the way we live because of their story.

I pray to them every day because they fit my “criteria” for inclusion in the list of the saints that I ask for help from every day. My criteria are a little bit

different than some. Of course, there are saints that I love greatly because of their piety and their holiness, such as St. Seraphim and St Nectarius, St. John of Shanghai, and San Francisco. And I pray to them every day, and on a good day, with a prostration each. I also pray to Saints that either became apostate and then came back to the faith and were martyred, or that were falsely accused and because of the inhumanity, greed, and injustice of men were offered the choice of converting to Islam and death with the demons, or to die in tortures (and gain eternal life)!

St. Constantine was a godly monarch. That already makes him different than almost any king. It is true that for most men, power corrupts and absolute power

corrupts absolutely. Constantine was not corrupted; he was a godly man who used his wealth, power and influence to help build monasteries and churches and to give alms to the poor. However, it is clear that he was a wealthy man. Wealth tends to make the soul dull.

In his old age, he was unable to keep up with taxes to the Turks, and was summoned to the Caliph. The caliph just wanted his money, and he didn't have any money. Near the end of his life, he was no longer wealthy a wealthy man as the world ways it's gold coins. He had a great treasure, but it was hidden in his heart, and also was plain to see, for those who have eyes to see, among his children. The Caliph saw none of this treasure. He wanted earthly mammon.

The noble Constantine and his children were accosted and given the choice of a gruesome martyrdom or conversion to Islam, with the absolving of all of his debts and making him again a very wealthy man with influence and comfort. He chose to die. He must've been a very good father because his children, upon seeing his example, also all chose to die. Their resolve did not come out of nowhere! They had seen the example of their father throughout their years growing up. Are we preparing our children for martyrdom, or are we living a life of ease and self-interest, and are they learning these sins from us? Do we pray for our children? Do we do prostrations for them? We cannot tell them we are Christians and then live in a secular way. They will know that we are imposters, and if we are imposters, who is going to teach them the way to eternal life?

Their father told them: "My children, take courage! We have lost everything in this world. Let us at least save our souls, washing our sins in our blood. Think of all that Christ endured for us! May your glorious faith not be shaken at this hour." And his godly children,

with their last act of obedience to their father, followed his example.

I am amazed by people who are in life situations that usually corrupt men, but live with piety and beauty of soul. Constantine is such a one. He had a son Matthew was very young, who at first abjured because of fear and said he would become a Moslem but his father whispered something in his ear, and the boy regained his resolve and said that he wanted to do that to die a Christian. His father told him: "it would be better to die a thousand times than to betray our faith, that no one can rest from us." Matthew regained his courage and calmly gave his head to the executioner, saying: "I want to die a Christian; go on, cut it off!"

Would we encourage our children in the faith, even if they are faced with suffering and deprivation and even death? Will we encourage them to live according to the truth even if the truth is painful and difficult for them? If we don't live according to the truth, with the resolve that we will keep the Christian faith no matter what the circumstances, how shall we expect our children to keep their faith? And how can we expect our children to listen to us if they see that our example is not good?

In our day, we need examples of courage. We also need examples of good. We need encouragement to do good, and we must learn skills to live according to the commandments, and against the way of the world. We can gain encouragement by reading the lives of the saints, and skills by begging their prayers, and reading the Psalter, and the Gospels, doing prostrations, and trying to live an interior life, and not a life with a shiny surface and no depth like most of the walking dead who are living out their lives unaware that they are squandering their purpose.

If we do not struggle against our passions, we will be annihilated by the destroyer. You can only destroy

those who are like him. Those who are unlike him are impervious to his manipulations and threats. He may be able to kill the body, but God will protect the soul.

This is why I pray to St. Constantine and his sons. And this is why I'm especially edified by the example of

NM Prince Constantine Brancoveanu & sons, Steven, Radu & Matthew & advisor Ianache Vacarescu, pray to God for us, that we be free of worldly attachments and live according to the commandments and be ready for whatever trial comes upon us because we are Christians. And also, King and father Constantine, pray that we are a better example to our children so that they are ready when their trials come. Amen!

In Christ, unworthy Priest Seraphim (seraphim@orthodox.net 972 658-5433).

The holy Prince Constantine Brancoveanu, the son of Prince Matthew Basarab, was born in 1654. When Prince Serban Cantacuzino died on October 19, 1688, Constantine was chosen to succeed him as Prince of the Romanian Land (Wallachia). Saint Constantine was a wise and just ruler who was guided by Christian principles, and worked for the benefit of his people. He also built and restored many churches and monasteries. His philanthropy extended even into Transylvania and Moldavia, which were ruled by others.

In 1714, after a reign of twenty-five years, Saint Constantine, his sons (Saints Constantine the Younger, Stephen Brancoveanu, Radu Brancoveanu, and Matthew Brancoveanu) and his sons-in-law were arrested by soldiers sent to Bucharest by Sultan Ahmed III (1703-1730), because he had been unable to pay the exorbitant taxes. The holy Prince endured all things and declared, as an old man aged 60, "if this trial comes from God because of my sins, may his will be done. If it is from the wickedness of men who desire my room, may God forgive my enemies."

His arrest was wholly because of the love of money. When the soldiers were unable to find much

money in the palace, they brought the prisoners, with prince's entire family and his faithful counselor to Constantinople, hoping to extract a ransom. He was tortured for four months, with such things as the wheel and red hot iron, and nails which are forced into his hands and feet.

Prince Constantine was told that if he and his sons wanted to escape death, they would have to convert to Islam and pay a large sum of money. Constantine did not have the money required by the Turks, and he did not wish to convert to the Moslem faith.

a father who was losing everything in this world, and his greatest concern was the salvation of his sons, which was only possible if their bodies were annihilated.

Seeing that neither tortures nor threats would induce the prisoners to forsake Christ, the Turks sentenced them to death.

On the day of Dormition, they were taken to the scaffold, before the Sultan and his viziers and gutless ambassadors from the great European powers. His youngest son Matthew was age 12 and walked to the head of the procession. They were made to kneel in rows. The holy Prince told his children: "My children, take courage! We have lost everything in this world. Let us at least save our souls, washing our sins in our blood. Think of all that Christ endured for us! May your glorious faith not be shaken at this hour." The eldest three sons were beheaded and when it came time for the child Matthew he was frightened and promised to become a Muslim. His father told him: "it would be better to die a thousand times than to betray our faith, that no one can rest from us." Matthew regained his courage and calmly gave his head to the executioner, saying: "I want to die a Christian; go on, cut it off!"

On the Feast of the Dormition (August 15), the sixty-year-old prince, his sons, and his counsellor Ianache Vacarescu died as martyrs for Christ. Their bodies were left unburied for three days, then they were thrown into the sea. Their relics were recovered by Orthodox Christians who brought them to the Monastery of the Theotokos on the island of Chalki. Saint Constantine's wife Marica brought his holy relics back to Bucharest and placed them in the church of Saint George the New, which he had founded. He was glorified by the Orthodox Church of Romania in 1992. (From my document "All Saints, pray for us!", which has a long list of saints that I pray to, and some of their lives. <http://www.orthodox.net/trebnic/saints-pray-for-us+former-apostates-sinners-secret-christians.docx> ; <http://www.orthodox.net/trebnic/saints-pray-for-us+former-apostates-sinners-secret-christians.pdf>)

Recent Stuff:

[Peter's experience on Tabor affected *everything* he did for the rest of his life; we may not see the Divine Light in this life, but we must *experience* God, and that experience *must* affect *everything* in our life.](#)

As he came to the end of his life, The apostle Peter justified everything he taught and did by the experience of being an “eye witness of (Jesus’) majesty” when Jesus was transfigured. We look at Peter’s epistle, where he makes this startling claim. Peter not only saw the majesty of God; he saw the promise of what God intends for man. He saw life and light. Everything thing he did from that point on was influenced by his experience and we also must do everything in our lives under the influence of our experience of God. It will not likely be that we see divine light, but we must experience God. We talk about how Peter experienced God on the day of the Transfiguration and how, as he grew to maturity, he understood this experience, and how this experience gave him the boldness to claim with confidence that even after his death he would be ministering to his flock. As an example of an experience of God that we regular people might have, I recall the day of my ordination to the diaconate. Our experience of God is certainly a “sure word of prophecy”, as much as it is much more subtle than the experience of Peter on Mount Tabor.

Incomplete (audio) Timestamps:

6:58 – 8:29 My ordination to the diaconate experience, and a comparison of the diaconal and priestly ministries.

15:36 – 17:21 About spiritual experiences of God, phenomena, etc. If we search for spiritual experiences, we will find them, but the light will be a dark light. The most common experience of God, attainable by even the simple and sinful.

2 Peter 1:10-19 10 Wherefore the rather, brethren, give diligence to make your calling and election sure: for if ye do these things, ye shall never fall: 11 For so an entrance shall be ministered unto you abundantly into the everlasting kingdom of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ. 12 Wherefore I will not be negligent to put you always in remembrance of these things, though ye know them, and be established in the present truth. 13 Yea, I think it meet, as long as I am in this tabernacle, to stir you up by putting you in remembrance; 14 Knowing that shortly I must put off this my tabernacle, even as our Lord Jesus Christ hath shewed me. 15 Moreover I will endeavour that ye may be able after my decease to have these things always in remembrance. 16 For we have not followed cunningly devised fables, when we made known unto you the power and coming of our Lord Jesus Christ, but were eyewitnesses of his majesty. 17 For he received from God the Father honour and glory, when there came such a voice to him from the excellent glory, This is my beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased. 18 And this voice which came from heaven we heard, when we were with him in the holy mount. 19 We have also a more sure word of prophecy; whereunto ye do well that ye take heed, as unto a light that shineth in a dark place, until the day dawn, and the day star arise in your hearts:

[“They need not depart.” The Feeding of the 5000](#)

Video: <https://youtu.be/Ah3wN1UYkvA>

Audio: http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pen-sun-08_2022+they-need-not-depart+feeding-5000.mp3

When the disciples were in a desperate situation in a desert place with thousands of hungry people and no means to feed them, the Lord told them that they need not depart. The apparent meaning of the statement is that it was a prelude to the multiplication of five loaves of bread into fishes to feed the multitude. The spiritual meaning applies to every day of our lives.

Partial Timestamps:

0-0:58 The primary theological meaning of the Feeding of the 5000. It is the beginning of a full understanding of the story.

0:58 – 4:11 “They need not depart...” part 1

2:14 – 4:11 The patience of the paralytic is that of a man who “did not depart.”

5:44 – 8:29 I am trying my best, which is not good -enough, but it is getting to be good enough. “They need not depart...” part 2

8:29 – 14:26 A tale from our history – Getting land, and “not departing” (with 2 hiccups) from prayer and patience until our church was built.

15:43 – 17:44 WHY did Jesus tell his disciples to get into a ship without Him after He fed the 5000? There is an apparent reason and a very important spiritual reason. “And straightway Jesus constrained his disciples to get into a ship, and to go before him unto the other side, while he sent the multitudes away.” (Matthew 14:22)

[Dogmatic Theotokion – Aposticha, Tone 7 2022-08-06](#)

Excellent for inquirers and catechesis of those who want to understand why and how we ask the intercessions of the Saints and the Theotokos. Commentary on the Dogmatic Theotokion for the Aposticha at Vespers for Sunday, Tone 7. “Having recourse under thy protection, O mistress, all we born of earth cry aloud to thee: O Theotokos, our hope, deliver us from our countless transgressions and save thou our souls.” All prayers to the Theotokos, and all Saints are dogmatic and Christological statements. We also explain why we pray things like “Most Holy Theotokos save us”, or in the case of this hymn: “deliver us from our countless transgressions.” This is because the participation of the Theotokos in the incarnation is part of the process of our salvation. It is also because we understand the resurrection and the many ways that God is pleased to impart grace to us. Perhaps our explanation will help those who are squeamish about the church’s prayer to the saints, and even mislabel it as idolatry or heresy. It is because they do not understand what we believe.

Video: <https://youtu.be/RQv8ubNYc4k>

Audio: http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/misc_2022+dogmatic-theotokion-aposticha-tone-07.mp3

Partial Timestamps: 0:18 “Having recourse under thy protection, O mistress, all we born of earth cry aloud to thee: O Theotokos, our hope, deliver us from our countless transgressions and save thou our souls.”

Video: <https://youtu.be/eF1nBOBDA7c>

Audio: http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/misc_2022+dogmatic-theotokion-tone-06.mp3

What is a “Dogmatic Theotokion?” We look at the one in Tone 6 in detail and discuss the resurrection, the incarnation, atheism, prayer to the saints, and rhetorical questions.

“Who doth not call thee blessed, * O all-holy Virgin? * Who will not hymn thine all-pure birthgiving? * For the only-begotten Son * Who shone forth timelessly from the Father, * came forth, ineffably incarnate, from thee, the pure one; * and being God by nature, He became man for our sake, * not divided into two Persons, * but known in two natures without confusion. * Him do thou beseech, * O pure and most blessed one, * that our souls find mercy!”

Partial Timestamps:

0:34- 1:28 “Who doth not call thee blessed, O all-holy Virgin, Who will not hymn thine all-pure birth-giving?” Answer all rhetorical questions!

1:28-3:39 “For the only-begotten son, Who shone forth timelessly from the Father came forth ineffably incarnate from thee, the pure one.”

3:42 – 7:30 “And being God by nature, He became man for our sake, not divided into two Persons, * but known in two natures without confusion.”

4:35 – 5:11 Why is atheism a denial of self?

6:06 – 7:30 The implications of Jesus Christi being “but known in two natures without confusion.”

8:13 - “11:26 Him do thou beseech, * O pure and most blessed one, * that our souls find mercy!”

9:54 - 11:26 God is not the God of the dead. He is the God of the living. Understanding the resurrection and the saints.